ASCII MASTER FLOW -- TOPIC 23: THE MARATHAS, SHIVAJI & AURANGZEB'S DECCAN; JAGIRDARI CRISIS (16 panels)

[1] DEFINITION & SETTING
  Topic 23 = Marathas' regional state formation under Shivaji (to 1680) + Aurangzeb's Deccan
  annexation and prolonged war (1680s-1707) + the jagirdari fiscal-administrative crisis that
  followed.
  Sahyadri ridge + Maval upland valleys + Konkan coastal creeks -> distributed base:
    ridge = passes/mobility | Maval = forts/supply | Konkan = customs/coastal contact/rival powers
  CAUTION: terrain enabled, but did not by itself create, Maratha state power (no geography-
  determinism).

[2] DECCAN SERVICE FIELD & SHAHJI BHONSLE
  Nizam Shahi Ahmadnagar (collapsing) -> Bijapur / Mughal / Golconda-adjacent service world.
  Shahji Bhonsle: mobile service politics, incl. support for a Nizam Shahi claimant -> Poona
  jagir/household. NOT a hereditary anti-Mughal crusade; NOT proto-nationalism.
  Jija Bai = household legitimacy/local authority (bounded); Dadoji Konddev = secure
  administrative actor in the Poona setting (not sole state-architect).

[3] STATE FORMATION: JAVLI -> FORTS -> AFZAL KHAN
  Javli, 1656: the More family's position removed -> Maval-Satara-Konkan routes opened
  (territorial capacity gained, not abolition of all hereditary rights).
  First forts, 1645-47 -> expanding fort-anchored base.
  Afzal Khan's death, Pratapgad, 1659: secure core (mutual suspicion, his death, Maratha
  gains) is certain; the exact first-blow sequence is bakhar-genre dependent, not primary
  certainty.

[4] MUGHAL CONTACT: SHAISTA KHAN -> SURAT -> PURANDAR -> AGRA
  1663: Poona night raid on Shaista Khan (bold strike, dents Mughal prestige; not a war-
  ending blow).
  1664: first sack of Surat (commercial disruption; factory records = merchant source, not
  a neutral or administrative one).
  1665: Jai Singh's siege+diplomacy -> Treaty of Purandar: 23/35 forts transferred, 12
  retained, Sambhaji granted mansab 5000 (incorporation attempt, NOT a final or
  unconditional surrender).
  1666: Agra detention -> prestige/rank crisis -> escape (secure); the basket-escape DETAIL
  is a popular-narrative element whose provenance is separately flagged, not an
  administrative record.

[5] SOVEREIGNTY: CORONATION & LEGITIMACY
  1674 Raigad coronation: Gaga Bhatta validates Kshatriya status -> Rajyabhisheka Shaka
  (royal era used on later documents/coins = bounded dating evidence, not a modern
  calendar reform).
  Legitimacy idiom = Hindu royal symbolism + Persianate administrative institutions + Muslim
  officers together -> plural legitimacy, NOT an exclusive Hindu-state formula.

[6] ADMINISTRATION: ASHTAPRADHAN & FORT-LOCAL CHECKS
  Ashtapradhan (8 offices: Peshwa, Amatya/Mazumdar, Sachiv, Mantri/Waqia-navis, Sumant/Dabir,
  Senapati, Nyayadhish, Panditrao) -> each individually ruler-responsible (NOT a collective
  cabinet answerable to a legislature); several offices combine civil+military duties.
  Fort level: Havaldar/sabnis command-store-record roles = a local administrative check.
  Village/provincial level: patils, kulkarnis, deshmukhs retained (illegal exactions curbed,
  hereditary local rights NOT abolished).

[7] REVENUE & FISCAL CLAIMS
  Annaji Datto's assessment, c.1679: strengthens jama (assessed demand) estimation; jama is
  not the same as hasil (realised collection) -- the gap is source-specific, not a universal
  rate.
  Chauth = one-fourth protection-linked claim (origin) -> widened into a political/fiscal
  claim over time.
  Sardeshmukhi = a separate ten-per-cent superior-deshmukh claim.
  Chauth and sardeshmukhi must stay distinct (different rate AND rationale); collection is
  not the same as settled sovereignty.

[8] MILITARY, NAVAL & FORT NETWORK
  Cavalry: bargir (state-provided horse) + silhedar (own horse); Mavali infantry; fort
  garrisons; intelligence networks.
  Remuneration MIXED: cash pay + plunder shares + local (mokasa-type) assignments -- not
  all-cash, not all-plunder.
  Ganimi kava = a repertoire of surprise, information, supply-disruption and avoidance of
  unfavourable battle; it COEXISTED with siege-holding (Panhala) and pitched battle (Salher)
  -- it does not exclude conventional warfare.
  Navy: gunboats, grabs, gallivats + trading/supply craft, based at Sindhudurg/Vijaydurg --
  a REGIONAL LITTORAL force (coastal defence, anti-Sidi operations, trade protection), NOT a
  blue-water empire navy.
  Fort network: storage + observation + signalling + short-radius movement across linked
  (not isolated) nodes.

[9] SUCCESSORS: SAMBHAJI -> RAJARAM/GINGEE -> TARABAI
Sambhaji (r.1680-89): succession constrained by Prince Akbar's alliance and Mughal pressure; captured at Sangameshwar, executed 1689 -- this removed a recognised negotiating head but did NOT end resistance; it shifted resistance toward dispersed commanders, forts and fiscal claims.
Rajaram: escaped to Gingee (Jinji) for strategic depth; the fort itself fell only in 1698, AFTER Rajaram had already escaped -- a fort's fall is not the same as its ruler's capture.
Santaji Ghorpade, Dhanaji Jadhav, Ramchandra Pant Amatya and Shankaraji Narayan sustained command, fiscal and administrative functions through decentralisation (not one frictionless organisation).
Rajaram d.1700 -> Tarabai becomes regent for her son Shivaji II.

[10] AURANGZEB'S ANNEXATION & PROLONGED WAR
Bijapur annexed 1686 -> Golconda annexed 1687: removed buffer states that had mediated Deccan politics; added territory, revenue claims and nobles, but ALSO required garrisons, administration and long, disturbed communications.
'Aurangzeb won Bijapur and Golconda but lost the Deccan' = an analytical paradox distinguishing MAP-CONQUEST from governable, revenue-realising authority -- not a contemporary court verdict, and not proof the annexations achieved nothing.
1700-05: a repetitive siege-recapture dynamic around Gingee and other forts -- operational success with weak strategic return.

[11] JAGIRDARI CRISIS MECHANISMS (multi-causal, NOT one single cause)
Rank inflation: Mughal khanazads + absorbed Deccani nobles/soldiers + Maratha-origin mansabdars all compete for a limited pool of productive jagirs.
Be-jagiri = a shortage of assignable productive jagirs (claimant pressure).
Jama-hasil gap = assessed revenue exceeding what is actually collected (the illustrative worked example 'jama 100, hasil 55' is a TEACHING MODEL, not a verified district statistic).
Paibaqi = land recorded as unassigned/awaiting assignment; paper status does not equal realised income.
Short jagirdar tenure/frequent transfers: meant to prevent entrenchment, instead encouraged quick extraction, bribery and factional competition -- weakening troop maintenance.
War disruption (long Deccan campaigns) -> lower realised hasil -> poorer jagir quality -> weaker troop maintenance -> more campaigning needed -> loop repeats.

[12] LOCAL POWER & MULTI-CAUSAL CONSEQUENCES
Zamindars, deshmukhs and local armed groups = neither pure officials nor simple landlords -- they bargained, resisted, or struck private pacts amid PARALLEL Mughal jama-hasil gaps and Maratha chauth claims in the same district, making sovereignty negotiable in practice.
Consequence chain: long communications raise logistics costs -> campaigning disturbs hasil -> poorer jagir quality weakens troop maintenance -> troop shortfalls make campaigning harder -> repeated campaigns intensify the disturbance (a closed loop, not a single 1707 event).
Matured under the Deccan war; interacts with Topic 22's Rajput rupture/religious-policy legitimacy issues; feeds the post-1707 transition that Topic 25 analyses in full (boundary, not scope creep).

[13] SOURCES, HISTORIOGRAPHY & FACT-RISK LEDGER
Genres show different things: Sabhasad Bakhar (courtly Maratha memory) | Mughal Persian chronicles (imperial perception; 'rebel/bandit' vocabulary is state perspective, not neutral description) | European factory records (commercial disruption/rumour, not Maratha ledgers) | forts/coins/inscriptions (capacity, legitimacy, spatial organisation).
Historiographical frames (nationalist / communal / Marxist-peasant / regional-state) must be tied to evidence, not asserted as automatically complete.
FACT-RISK LEDGER (six items needing qualified language): early-fort action wording; Afzal Khan's exact first blow; Agra's basket-escape detail; revenue-incidence figures; Hindavi Swarajya's provenance; navy size (must not be inflated).

[14] PYQ STATUS, ANSWER SPINE & TRAPS
No verified DIRECT Topic-23 Prelims PYQ exists for 2018-2026; the 2018/2019/2022/2024 items are ROUTED to other topics (a Modern-History keyword hit; Topic 24 Mughal administration; Modern-era European settlements; Topic 09 Indian-Ocean trade/ports) on subject-matter grounds -- marks are NOT item-stated in the official record, so a fixed mark value should not be asserted.
ANSWER SPINE: (1) frame geography as enabling, not determining -> (2) state formation via forts, revenue and legitimacy, not romantic myth -> (3) plural legitimacy plus a real administrative structure -> (4) a multi-causal jagirdari crisis, not 'too many mansabdars' alone -> (5) qualify contested details using the fact-risk ledger.
RECURRING TRAPS: geography-determinism; treating Purandar or the coronation as final; collapsing chauth/sardeshmukhi into one claim; inflating the navy to blue-water scale; single-cause jagirdari-crisis claims; conflating a fort's fall with its ruler's capture.

[15] HERITAGE & CURRENT LINKAGE (dated, bounded; not historical proof)
  2025: UNESCO's 'Maratha Military Landscapes' listing names twelve component forts --
  present-day heritage recognition, usable as a bounded bridge into the historical
  argument, NOT primary evidence for any specific seventeenth-century battle or force size.
  2026: a PIB conservation/site-management release -- a separate, later, administratively
  distinct item; it must not be merged with the 2025 listing or treated as seventeenth-
  century evidence.

[16] TOPIC BOUNDARY (scope discipline)
  Topic 18 = Mughal policy through 1657 | Topic 22 = religion/Rajput/North India |
  Topic 23 (HERE) = Marathas/Shivaji/Aurangzeb's Deccan/jagirdari crisis |
  Topic 24 = society/economy/culture | Topic 25 = post-1707 confederate period.